ART

OBJECTS OF DESIRE

***BHASHA CHAKRABARTI**'s first solo show derives and extends from Ismat Chughtai's short story* Lihaaf

COURTESY: EXPERIMENTER, PHOTOGRAPHS BY ABNER FERNANDES





QUILT CONNECTION
'Karvat (صبح)/The Turn (Morning)'; (left) 'Karvat (रात)/ The Turn (Night)'

When it was published in 1942, Ismat Chughtai's most (in)famous work *Lihaaf* (The Quilt) sparked outrage—and an obscenity trial—for its depiction of queer, inter-generational intimacy. Begum Jaan and her masseuse/lover Rabbo explore desire in the safety of the quilt, an act witnessed by Begum Jaan's young, distant relative. Everything is suggestive, narrated by an adolescent scared by the recurrent and seemingly violent phenomenon of the quilt rising, swirling, and eventually falling flat in the dark of the night. A quilter before she was a painter, Bhasha Chakrabarti extends the carnality of Begum Jaan's quilt in her solo show, entitled کروٹ | करवट | *Karvat, which means* to toss and turn in bed.

Spread over multiple rooms, Chakrabarti's works refer to different types of turns, be they metaphorical, material, or physical. Right at the outset, the installation 'Kaghazi Hai Pairahan' catches the eye, a paper quilt made by pulping and layering Urdu, Hindi, and English translations of *Lihaaf*. It uses the Japanese method of Kakishibu where a dye made using persimmon juice acts as a curative and preservative agent. On the opposite wall, 'Karvat (صبح)/The Turn (Morning)' uses reappropriated fabric to construct a quilt, its folds covering a body (or perhaps two) with a face or limb slipping out from underneath. Elsewhere in the gallery, its counterpart, 'Karvat (रात)/ The Turn (Night)' depicts a similar scene but at night, which is the primary part of Chughtai's story, where all the action happens. Here, the drapery of the body takes over the entire view of the painting and begins to resemble a cloudscape or a skyscape. Nearby, you see an actual cloudscape painted on a kitchen towel. "The tea towel is a very ordinary domestic object, but throughout the show you see these ordinary objects turning into sites of wonder, a simple kitchen towel becoming a window to this full moon night sky," says Chakrabarti.



SPREAD OVER MULTIPLE ROOMS, **CHAKRABARTI'S WORKS REFER TO DIFFERENT TYPES OF TURNS**, METAPHORICAL, MATERIAL OR PHYSICAL

Ordinary objects are also at the forefront in the central room—Begum Jaan's zenana—painted a Venetian red, referencing Matisse's oil-on-canvas painting 'The Red Studio' (1911). The red colour comes from hematite sourced from mining waste, which Chakrabarti has been milling to extract her own pigments. In this 'Ajaibghar', found furniture is painted red with golden borders, and imbued with music—a nod to the Deccani Ragamala paintings in the Indian Museum in Calcutta. Each furniture piece corresponds to a raga and the viewer is invited to physically open the piece to hear a classical rendition accompanied by a painting of an unexpected scene. ■

–Prachi Joshi

The exhibition continues ***until Dec. 20 at Experimenter–Colaba, Mumbai***